CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PPC / PAID ADS SPECIALIST IN THE AI ERA

Businesses hand these people real money daily and ask one question: did it come back with friends?

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K, remote, no credentials required, learnable in 1–6 months. The catch: platforms automate bidding and creative — the human value is strategy, offers and honest measurement. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

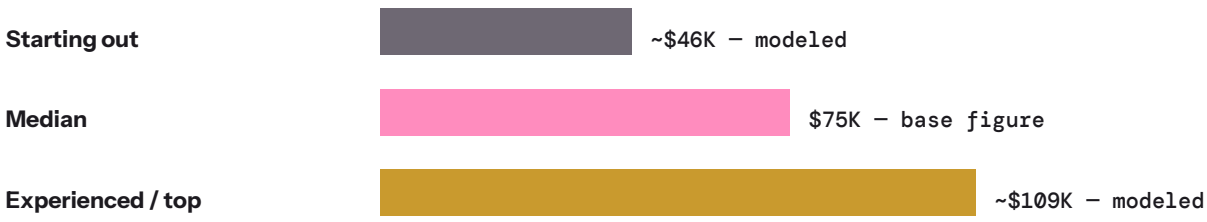
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK MEDIUM

- PPC is advertising with a spreadsheet attached: Google Ads, Meta Ads, budgets, tests, returns.
- Platform certificates are free and quick — they open agency doors more than most fields' credentials do.
- AI optimizes bids and generates ad variants; humans choose offers, audiences and what 'profitable' means.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for PPC / Paid Ads Specialist is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PPC / PAID ADS SPECIALIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Build and manage ad campaigns on Google, Meta and other platforms
- ✓ Write and test ad copy, audiences and landing page pairings
- ✓ Watch budgets daily and move money from losers to winners
- ✓ Report return on ad spend in language a business owner respects

Think: a trader, but the stock is attention — you buy clicks cheap, sell them dear, and the market reprices hourly.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Automated bidding, broad targeting and AI-generated creative now do the platform's mechanical work. Campaign babysitting as a full-time job is ending.	Offer strategy, creative direction, funnel diagnosis and the honesty to kill a beloved campaign. Business judgment stays human.

⚠ **You will be judged on other people's products and websites too — a great ads manager can't save a bad offer, but will be blamed for trying.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Direct line from your work to revenue — credit is legible ✓ Agency, freelance and in-house demand ✓ Fast feedback: campaigns teach you weekly	✗ Clients panic-spend and panic-cut on a weekly rhythm ✗ Platforms change interfaces and rules constantly ✗ Weekend campaigns don't care about your weekend

Good fit? You're numerate, competitive, and comfortable making decisions with a client's real money on incomplete data.
Bad fit? Numbers feel cold to you, or losing money — even experimentally — makes you freeze.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PLATFORM CERTS + AGENCY	DOOR B — ONE CLIENT, SMALL BUDGET

Take the free Google and Meta certifications, then enter an agency where seniors review your accounts. Agency volume — many accounts, many industries — is the fastest teacher in this field.	Start with a local business on a modest budget, performance-based if needed. One real account with real money teaches faster than any course — and becomes your case study.

Smart move: Learn landing pages, not just ads. The specialist who can fix the page the click lands on charges double, because that's usually where the money leaks.
Where you land after: Senior paid media specialist → growth lead / performance marketing manager, or a niche ad agency.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
PLATFORM FUNDAMENTAL	FREE CERTIFICATI	TRACKING AND	FIRST REAL	CREATIVE TESTING	SCALE THE

STEP 1 — Platform fundamentals

FREE · WEEKS 1-3

- Google Ads structure: campaigns, keywords, match types, quality signals.
- Meta Ads structure: objectives, audiences, placements, the pixel.

STEP 2 — Free certifications

FREE · WEEKS 3-6

- Pass the Google Ads and Meta Blueprint certificates — they're free and agencies do filter on them.
- Build every concept in a demo account as you study it.

STEP 3 — Tracking and measurement

FREE · MONTHS 1-2

- Conversion tracking, analytics, attribution honesty — know what a sale is worth and what you can't prove.
- This is the skill that separates professionals from button-pushers.

STEP 4 — First real account

MONTHS 2-4

- A local business or your own small project, real budget, weekly optimization log.
- Document decisions and results like a case study from day one.

STEP 5 — Creative testing craft

MONTHS 3-5

- Ad copy and creative testing systems — hypotheses, rotations, winners scaled.
- Learn the basics of the landing pages your ads point to.

STEP 6 — Scale the lane MONTHS 4-6

- Agency seat or 2–3 freelance clients; specialize by industry as results accumulate.
- Raise rates on documented return, not on months served.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- ☐ Today: create advertiser accounts and open the free Google Ads certification path.
- ☐ Days 1–30: Google fundamentals done; demo campaigns built; tracking installed on a test site.
- ☐ Days 31–60: both platform certificates passed or scheduled; first real account pitched or live.
- ☐ Days 61–90: weekly optimization running with a decision log; first results documented.
- ☐ Day 90: free credentials, real budget experience, and a case-study draft — agency-ready.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ CLICKS COST. CUSTOMERS PAY. KNOW THE DIFFERENCE. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.